



Harikrishnan becomes India's 87th Grandmaster

For seven years, Harikrishnan A. Ra. remained an International Master. During that time, he competed in numerous tournaments in pursuit of the Grandmaster title but repeatedly fell short, often coming agonisingly close. The 23-year-old, coached by Shyam Sundar, finally earned his third and final GM norm at the La Plagne International Chess Festival in France. A draw with compatriot P. Inian in the final round secured him a fourth-place finish and confirmed his status as India's 87th Grandmaster.

Speaking from La Plagne (France), Harikrishnan expressed a sigh of relief.

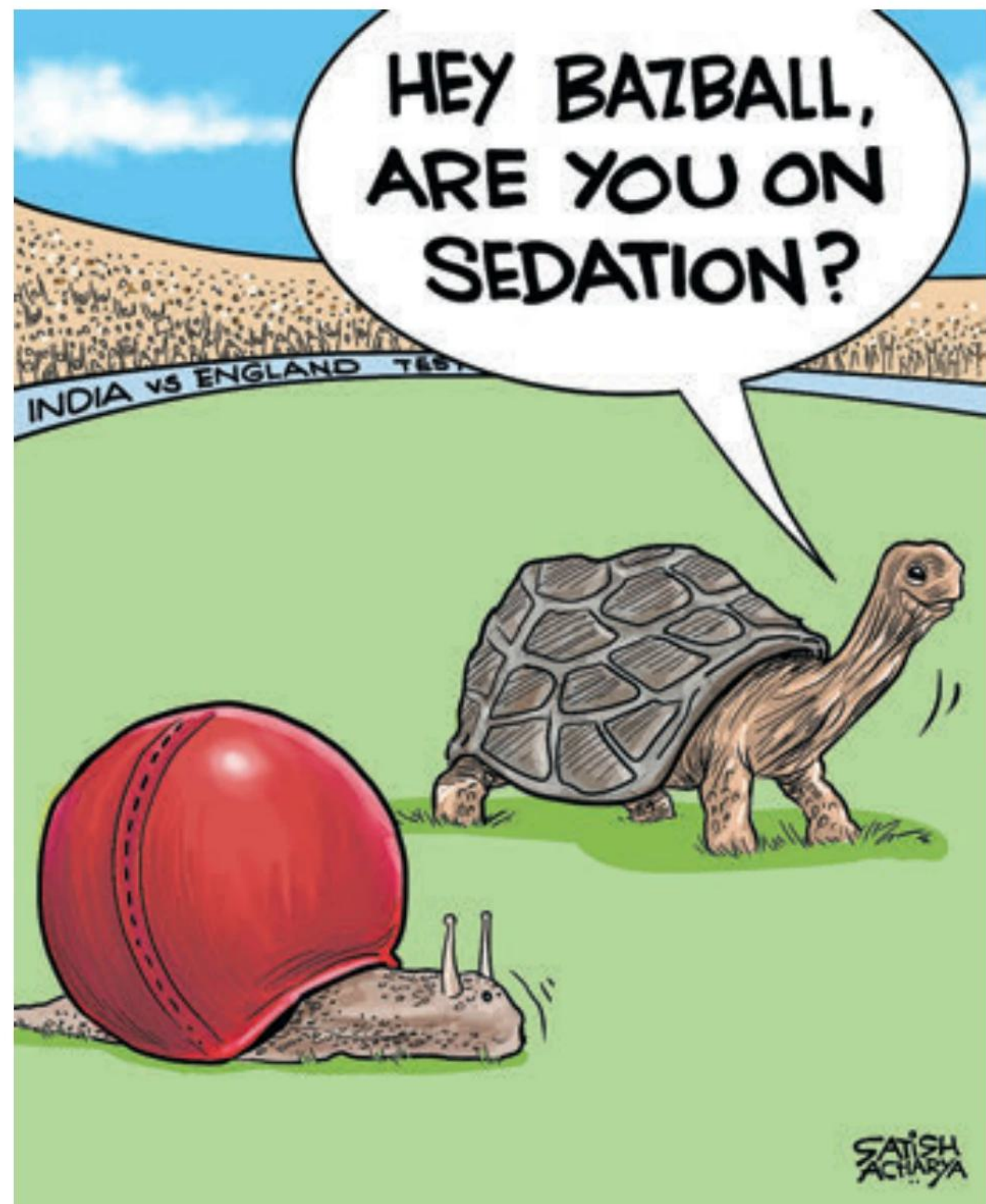
"Feel very happy. It's been seven years. I agree there was a huge delay in becoming a GM. From 2022, I have been competing regularly in tournaments, but couldn't get the GM norms. It was a struggle," Harikrishnan told Sportstar.

He achieved his first GM norm at the Biel International Chess Festival in Switzerland in 2023, followed by his second at the Lince Andujar Chess Open in June this year in Spain. Harikrishnan knew he needed 1.5 points from the last two rounds to become a GM. "There was pressure and I am glad I did it," he said.

K. KEERTHIVASAN

» INDIAN PLAYGROUND

SPORTOON



1 The Kalinga Stadium has undergone some infrastructural changes to host the one-day World Athletics (WA) Continental Tour Bronze Level meet — a qualifying event for the World championships in Japan in September — on August 10. Around 150 athletes — including 50 from abroad — are expected to take part in the meet, representing 12 countries such as Turkmenistan, Bhutan, the Philippines, South Korea, Malaysia, Iraq, Vietnam, Cameroon, Sri Lanka, Iran, the Maldives, and host nation India.

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2 In a move signalling continued confidence in ongoing reform efforts, World Boxing has extended the tenure of the interim committee, led by Ajay Singh, overseeing the Boxing Federation of India (BFI) till August 31, 2025. This decision acknowledges the structured efforts made by the interim committee to bring back transparency and stability to the BFI's operations. World Boxing had appointed an interim committee in April this year to run the day-to-day affairs of the BFI.

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